

High-Growth in the Thames Valley

Mapping out the most ambitious businesses in the Thames Valley and analysing the impact of COVID-19

What do we mean by “ambitious”?

We use 8 criteria to identify high-growth and ambitious companies. Each of these is a sign of external validation that a business is either actively growing or creating ambitious growth plans.

All companies featured in this report have met at least one of these growth triggers, and are headquartered in the counties of Oxfordshire, Berkshire or Buckinghamshire.



Equity investment



Venture debt



Accelerator attendance



Grant recipients



Scaleups



High-growth lists



MBO/MBI



Academic spinouts

Methods of growth

69% of high-growth companies in the Thames Valley have used equity funding since 2011 to grow, much more than the national average of **51%**.

24% of the high-growth companies in the Thames Valley have reached scaleup status, exactly in line with the national average.

The region has a high proportion of university spinout companies (**11%**), thanks to the very active commercialisation arm of the University of Oxford.

Raised equity

949

Visible scaleups

409

Received grants

322

Spun out of a university

149

Attended accelerators

291

Featured on a high-growth list

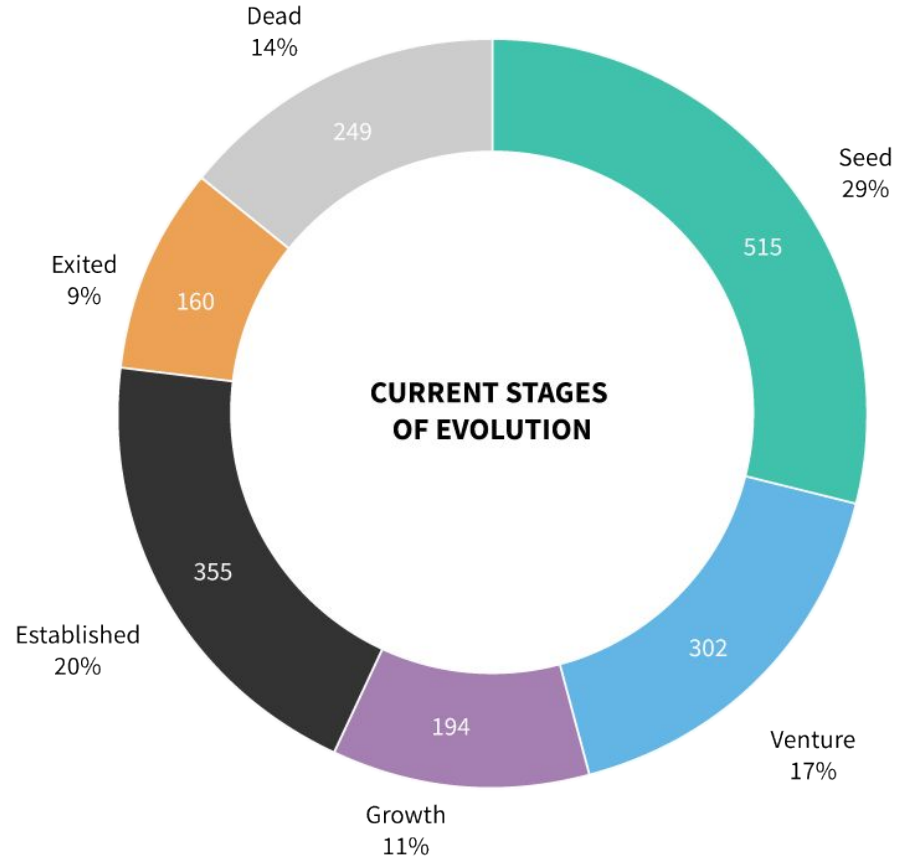
391

Stages of evolution

There are **1,366** active, ambitious companies in the Thames Valley, **5%** of the UK's total.

Since 2011, an additional **160** have exited the market, either through an IPO or an acquisition, and **249** are no longer trading.

9% of companies in the Thames Valley have exited, compared to the national average of **7%**. Slightly fewer high-growth companies in the Thames Valley have died: **14%** compared to the national average of **15%**.

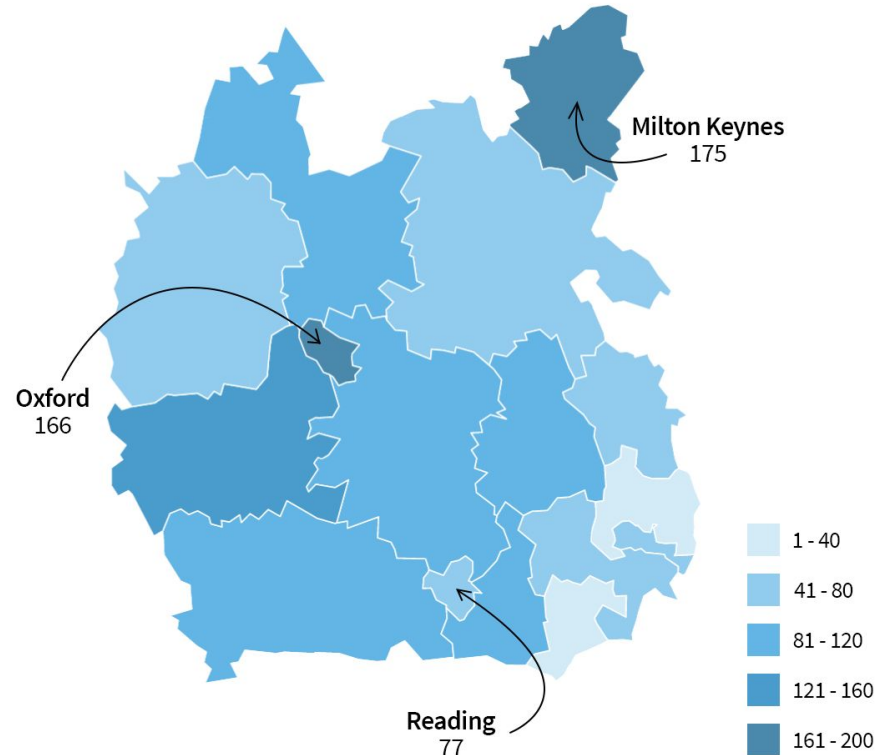


Geographical distribution

When we cut the Thames Valley region by local authority, Milton Keynes comes out as the most populous area of high-growth companies. Most of these businesses are operating within business and professional services, including Software-as-a-Service and marketing tools.

Oxford is the next most populous area, playing host to 166 high-growth companies, 66 of which are academic spinouts. It's no surprise then, that many of the companies are operating across pharmaceuticals, research tools and reagents and artificial intelligence.

NUMBER OF HIGH-GROWTH COMPANIES BY LOCAL AUTHORITY



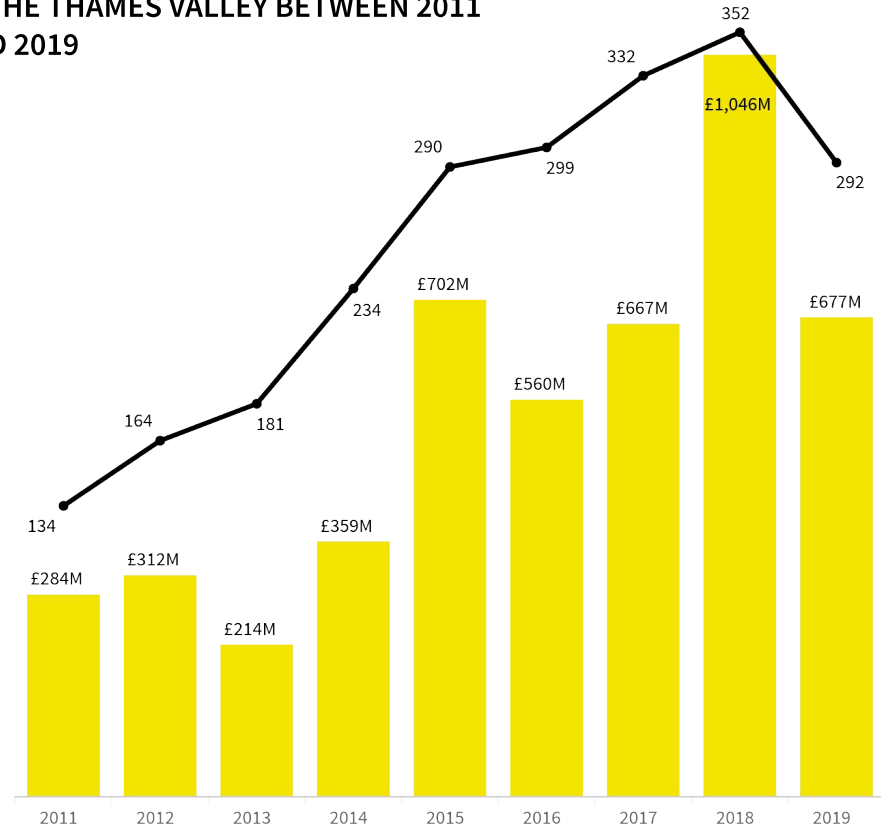
Fundraising statistics

Equity investment into companies in the Thames Valley peaked in 2018 when they raised over a **£1b**.

This amount fell dramatically in 2019, despite the overall amount invested in the UK as a whole reaching a new record of **£12B**.

The number of deals completed also saw a sharp decline, returning to a similar level seen in 2015.

EQUITY INVESTMENT INTO COMPANIES
IN THE THAMES VALLEY BETWEEN 2011
AND 2019



Top investors

Crowdcube and Seedrs regularly feature as top facilitators of investment across the UK by number of deals completed, so it's unsurprising to see both crowdfunding platforms feature on the ranking of most active investors in the Thames Valley.

Oxford Sciences Innovation (OSI) and Parkwalk are prominent investors in the Thames Valley on account of their relationship with the University of Oxford.

These funds have 11 portfolio companies in common in the region, including Animal Dynamics, Opsydia and YASA Motors

2019 TOP INVESTORS INTO THE THAMES VALLEY

Crowdcube	11
OSI	7
Seedrs	4
Parkwalk	4

Spinout stats

Unsurprisingly the University of Oxford is responsible for the majority of the spinouts in the Thames Valley, having spun out **109** companies since 2011.

Perhaps the most notable of these is unicorn company Oxford Nanopore, which develops a range of portable DNA and RNA sequencing devices, that are also capable of characterising epigenetic modifications.

The Science and Technology Facilities Council is responsible for **6** spinouts in the Thames Valley, as is Imperial College.

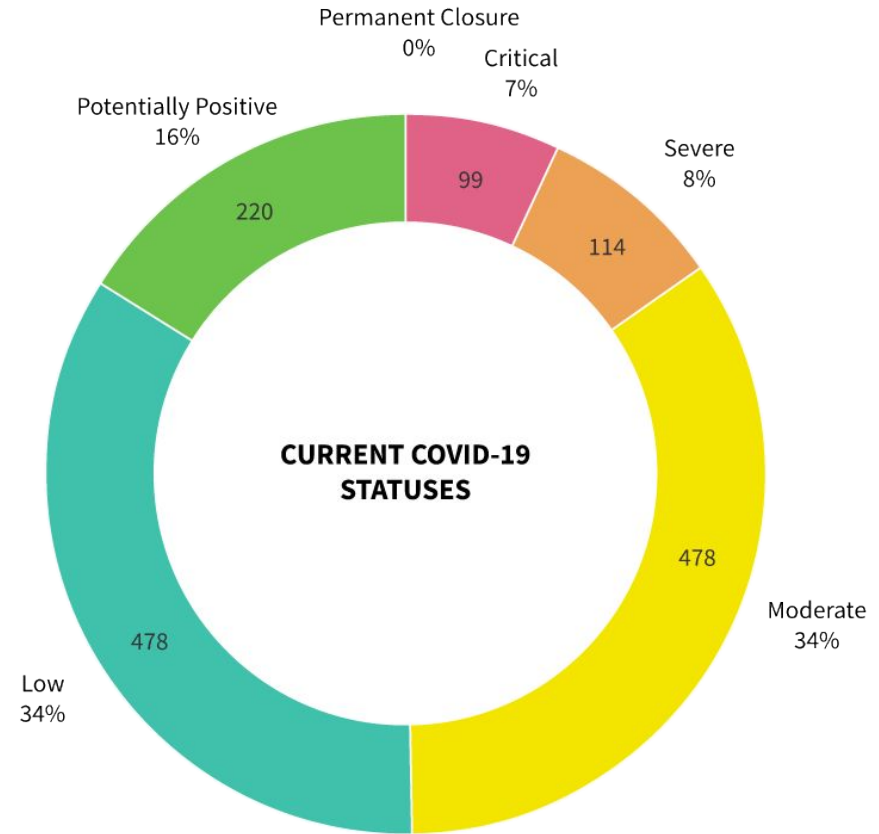
TOP UNIVERSITIES BY NUMBER OF THAMES VALLEY SPINOUTS SINCE 2011

University of Oxford	109
STFC	6
Imperial College London	6
University of Birmingham	3

Impact of COVID-19

The impact of COVID-19 on Thames Valley businesses is akin to the wider country, with around half of companies experiencing a low or potentially positive impact, and just over a third seeing a moderate impact. **15%** are at severe or critical risk, and will need additional support to make it through the pandemic.

The 154 Thames Valley businesses operating within the medical and life sciences sectors, including Oxford Nanopore and Immunocore, are far less likely to be negatively affected—just 27% are facing moderate to critical risk. Another **22%** are likely to experience a positive impact.



Top companies by amount of equity funding raised



Oxford Nanopore Technologies develops a range of portable DNA and RNA sequencing devices.

Location

Oxford

Stage of evolution

Growth

Total amount of equity raised

£522m

Number of rounds completed

12



Gigaclear provide ultrafast fibre-optic internet to homes and businesses in rural communities.

Location

Abingdon

Stage of evolution

Growth

Total amount of equity raised

£330m

Number of rounds completed

8



Immunocore develops drugs to treat cancer, viral infections and autoimmune diseases.

Location

Abingdon

Stage of evolution

Growth

Total amount of equity raised

£251m

Number of rounds completed

10

Top companies by value of grants received



TRL develops transport systems and researches technologies such as self-driving vehicles.

Location

Wokingham

Stage of evolution

Established

Total amount received

£11.2m

Number of grants received

18



YASA Motors develops and manufactures electric motors for automobiles.

Location

Kidlington

Stage of evolution

Growth

Total amount received

£11m

Number of grants received

7



Oxbotica develops software for driverless vehicles using features such as cameras and lasers.

Location

Oxford

Stage of evolution

Growth

Total amount received

£10.9m

Number of grants received

12

Explore all the ambitious companies in the UK

Beauhurst is a searchable database of the UK's most ambitious companies – from seed-stage startups to growing scaleups and beyond.

We collect and manually curate hundreds of data-points on over 30,000 companies, so you can find, engage and win high-value clients faster than ever before.

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